CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

COSMETOLOGIST / HAIR STYLIST IN THE AI ERA

The licence is real. So is the federal data: the median cosmetology graduate earns about $20K four years after finishing school.

★ TL;DR — NO — this one dies on entry economics, not AI. BLS puts the stylist median at ~$35,800 ($17.21/hr, May 2025), not the $45K the old card carried; that was booked-out stylist money. The beginner evidence is worse: New America/RTI's analysis of federal data puts median graduates of federal-aid cosmetology programmes at ~$20,000 four years out — below high-school-only workers in all 50 states — carrying $10–14K of debt. The roadmap below is the way OUT: same hands, same people skills, pointed at beauty seats with a ladder. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

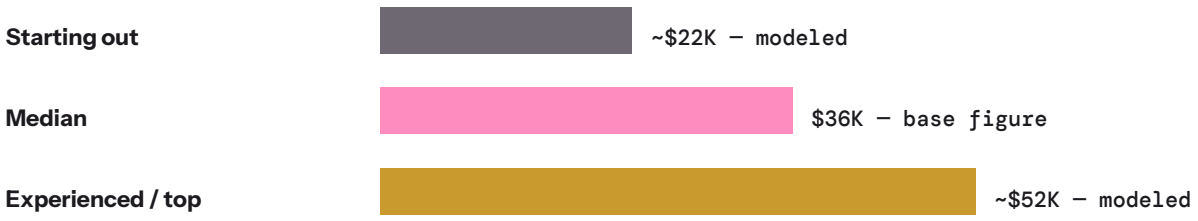
OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$36K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Fails as a start because: the first job pays commission (typically 40–50%, junior splits from 40/60 to ~50/50) on chairs you don't yet fill, and the federal graduate data — ~$20K at four years — shows how long 'building a book' actually takes.
- The licence is not the moat it looks like: it gates a $35,800-median occupation whose bottom decile earns under $13.00/hr, and 48% of stylists are self-employed, renting discovery from platforms that take 20–30% of a new client's first visit.
- Still worth money: hair skill, colour chemistry and client trust are real assets — esthetics and massage therapy pay for the same assets inside licensed occupations with ladders and higher ceilings.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Cosmetologist / Hair Stylist is a ~$36K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A COSMETOLOGIST / HAIR STYLIST ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Cut, color, treat and style hair for a rotating book of clients
- ✓ Consult honestly: what their hair can and cannot do
- ✓ Rebook, upsell care products and fill your own chair
- ✓ Keep tools, station and products clean, stocked and safe

Think: part artist, part chemist, part therapist — standing up, paid only when the chair is full.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Booking, reminders, formula records and marketing posts automate well. L'Oréal's ModiFace and YouCam virtual try-on move the colour consultation into free apps — useful previews, but they also absorb the consult conversation that used to start in your chair.	Reading real hair — texture, damage, cowlicks — and cutting it once, correctly, on a head that remembers. No AI cuts hair and no robot is deployed doing it. This NO is not about machines taking the work; it's about what the work pays a beginner.

⚠ **Distrust the two numbers schools and salons lead with: the $45K 'average' (that's the established tier — the 90th percentile is ~$71,200, the median $35,800, the floor decile under $27,040) and 'be your own boss' booth rental (~$400/mo average rent, owed before you have a single regular). Beginners start on commission splits, with product-cost deductions that can cut effective take-home toward 25%, plus 15.3% self-employment tax.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT

✓ Creative, social work with instant visible results ✓ Clients who become genuine regulars and friends ✓ A skill you can carry to any town in the country	✗ Years of low commission before a book pays ✗ Nights, weekends and wedding mornings are prime time ✗ On your feet all day, breathing chemistry

Good fit? You already have a following, a runway of savings, and treat school as buying a business — not as a route to a first paycheck.
Bad fit? You need the licence to become a living this year, or the school debt only makes sense at $45K.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Esthetician	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Massage Therapist
The licensed beauty seat with an actual ladder. BLS median $45,330 (Skincare Specialists), growth +9%, ~14,200 openings a year — and a 90th percentile of $82,050, because master/advanced licence tiers gate the laser and device work where they exist and physician offices pay a ~$51,600 median. Your consultation manner, sanitation discipline and rebooking instincts transfer directly. First move: pick a 600–750-hour esthetics programme and aim at W-2 med-spa or physician-office work, not a suite.	The widest licensed door in beauty and wellness: BLS median $58,450, growth +15%, ~20,400 openings a year, and chains hire at zero experience. A 500–1,000-hour programme plus the MBLEx puts you in a healthcare occupation whose top decile earns $100,200. First move: compare programmes by supervised clinic hours — the same comparison you were about to run on cosmetology schools, pointed at a seat that pays.

Smart move: If you stay in beauty, buy the seat with the ladder: device tiers and clinical settings are where the pay steps live. A flat licence under a ~$50K ceiling is a treadmill, not a ladder.
Where you land after: You land in licensed skin or body work where the median is real, employers supply the clients, and each tier you add raises the rate — instead of renting a chair and hoping.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	PRICE THE	PICK YOUR	CONVERT WHAT	ENROLL IN	KEEP HAIR

STEP 1 — Read the graduate data

FREE · TODAY

- New America/RTI: median cosmetology graduates earn ~$20K four years out, below high-school-only workers in all 50 states
- Set it next to the BLS all-worker median of ~$35,800 — and ask why the old card said $45K

STEP 2 — Price the real entry

WEEK 1

- Model a junior year: 40–50% commission on a half-empty chair, minus product charges and self-employment tax
- Add booth rent (~$400/mo average) if you'd skip employment — and watch what it does to the math

STEP 3 — Pick your door

WEEK 2

- Door A keeps the beauty counter: esthetics, licensed, with device tiers above it
- Door B keeps the hands-on care: massage therapy, healthcare pay, chain hiring at 0 years

STEP 4 — Convert what transfers

WEEKS 2-4

- Consultation, sanitation and rebooking skills count in both doors — name them on applications
- Cosmetology hours don't transfer as credit; your client manner does

STEP 5 — Enroll in the ladder

WEEKS 3-8

- Esthetics: a 600–750-hour programme. Massage: 500–1,000 hours plus the MBLEx
- Choose by clinic hours and board pass rates, not the brochure

STEP 6 — Keep hair priced honestly

ONGOING

- Cosmetology stays open later — with a book, a specialty and savings, the math changes
- Entering booked is a business launch; entering broke is a $20K graduate statistic

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: read the New America/RTI graduate figures next to the BLS median — $20K vs $35.8K vs the $45K you were quoted.

□ Days 1–30: junior-year math done; door chosen; esthetics or massage programmes compared by clinic hours.

□ Days 31–60: enrolled in the ladder programme; hands in supervised clinic work.

□ Days 61–90: clinic hours accumulating; employer settings (med-spa, physician office, chain) researched for graduation.

□ Day 90: you're training inside a licensed occupation whose median and ceiling both beat the chair you left.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

· Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test

· Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ BUY THE LADDER, NOT THE CHAIR. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.